

PETITION OF THE COCONUT FARMERS OF CHITTUR ASSEMBLY CONSTITUENCY

Palakkad District, Kerala — represented by Arun

POLLUTION-CATEGORY PARITY FOR COIR PROCESSING IN CHITTUR

Why Pollachi (Tamil Nadu) became a coir-processing hub while Chittur — with the same husk, 80 km away — did not

To: The Hon'ble Minister in charge of Pollution Control (Environment), Government of Kerala, Thiruvananthapuram.

(Administrative Department of the Kerala State Pollution Control Board.)

Copy to: 1. The Hon'ble Chief Minister of Kerala.

2. The Hon'ble Minister for Industries & Commerce, Government of Kerala.

From: The coconut farmers of the Chittur Assembly Constituency, Palakkad District, Kerala — represented by **Arun** and delegation.

Date: [] July 2026, Thiruvananthapuram.

Subject: Request to re-align the pollution-control category of coconut-husk retting (presently Red) and coir de-fibring / ginning (presently Orange) in Kerala with the Central (CPCB) norms and with Tamil Nadu's White-category treatment of the identical process chain — so that coir processing develops in Chittur instead of migrating across the border to Pollachi.

1. The prayer in one line

We are coconut farmers of the Chittur Assembly Constituency. We grow the coconut; the husk that comes off it is coir's raw material. We ask the Government to fix a single, provable anomaly: **Kerala places coconut-husk retting in the Red category and coir de-fibring / ginning in the Orange category, while both the Central norm and neighbouring Tamil Nadu treat the very same activities as practically non-polluting (White).** That one gap has sent the industry — and our husk's value — across the border to Pollachi.

2. The classification gap — Kerala vs. Tamil Nadu vs. the Central (CPCB) norm

The table below sets each coir activity against its category in Kerala (KSPCB), Tamil Nadu (TNPCB) and the Central norm (CPCB). The divergence is confined to the **primary end** of the chain:

Coir activity	Kerala (KSPCB)	Tamil Nadu (TNPCB)	Central (CPCB)	Where the outlier is
Coconut-husk retting	RED	WHITE	Not a Red / Orange sector †	Kerala alone — Red vs. White elsewhere
Coir de-fibring / ginning	ORANGE	WHITE	White / Green (dry) †	Kerala alone — Orange vs. White elsewhere
Coir fibre / pith processing generating effluent	GREEN	WHITE	GREEN	Kerala & CPCB stricter than TN
Coir bleaching / dyeing / stencilling (chemical, wet)	ORANGE	WHITE	ORANGE	Kerala aligned with CPCB
Dry coir processing / coir products without effluent	WHITE	WHITE	WHITE	Fully aligned
Coir yarn without dyeing	WHITE	WHITE	WHITE	Fully aligned

Coir activity	Kerala (KSPCB)	Tamil Nadu (TNPCB)	Central (CPCB)	Where the outlier is
Coir-pith final product; coir rope; curled coir	WHITE	WHITE	WHITE	Fully aligned

† CPCB's 2016 categorisation list places "Manufacturing of coir items from coconut husks" in the White category; its 2023 draft re-categorisation places dry coir processing in Green, coir items in White, and only wet / dyeing coir in Orange. CPCB does not list ordinary husk retting or dry de-fibring as a Red sector.

Read down the last column: on **five of seven** activities the three regulators broadly agree. The entire dispute is the **top two rows** — retting and de-fibring / ginning — where **Kerala stands alone** in imposing Red / Orange treatment on activities that Tamil Nadu and the Central norm regard as White.

3. Why this made Pollachi the hub and left Chittur out

Category is not a label — it decides whether a small unit can exist. A **White** activity needs **no Consent to Operate**; a simple intimation suffices, and the unit can start almost at once. A **Red** activity needs a full Consent to Establish and Consent to Operate and can attract **public-hearing-tier scrutiny**; an **Orange** activity needs the same consents plus periodic monitoring. For a cottage / MSME coir unit, that is the difference between opening and not opening.

So a coir entrepreneur — including many from Kerala — does the obvious thing: he sets up retting and de-fibring **80 km away in Pollachi**, where they are White, and leaves Chittur out. The result on the ground:

- **The husk moves, not the value.** Our coconut husk is carted to Pollachi, processed there, and the fibre, pith, jobs and margins are booked in Tamil Nadu.
- **Pollachi is a coir cluster; Chittur is a supplier of raw husk.** The same raw material and the same process chain, but the primary industry clustered on the side of the border where the category is lighter.
- **Farmers lose twice.** We forgo the price a local processing demand would give our husk, and we forgo the local employment that retting, de-fibring and pith units would create in the Chittur belt.

4. The re-alignment is squarely within the Central norm — not a dilution of safeguards

Classification is governed by a national, Pollution-Index (PI) methodology. The **CPCB Directions dated 07-03-2016 (No. B-29012/ESS(CPA)/2015-16)**, under **Section 18(1)(b) of the Water (Prevention and Control of Pollution) Act, 1974**, fix the tiers by PI — **Red ≥ 60 , Orange 41–59, Green 21–40, White ≤ 20** — carried forward by the CPCB Directions of 2025. On that very scale a dry mechanical **de-fibring / ginning** operation is low-index and is treated as White; the Central list itself places coir manufacturing from coconut husks in White.

Tamil Nadu proved the point in practice. By proceedings dated **10-11-2021** TNPCB moved coir from White to Orange; after representations from coir associations it **withdrew** that on **12-10-2023**, restoring the "coconut-husk retting / de-fibering / pith-processing industry" to White, expressly to protect the agro-based cottage MSME sector (Annexure B). Retting does use water — but that is best handled by **Zero-Liquid-Discharge at a shared Common Facility Centre**, exactly as Tamil Nadu does, not by a Red-category barrier that simply exports the industry.

5. Our prayer

We humbly request the Hon'ble Minister in charge of Pollution Control, in consultation with the Chief Minister and the Minister for Industries, to direct the Kerala State Pollution Control Board to:

1. **Reclassify coir de-fibring / ginning from Orange to White** (a dry mechanical process, as the Central norm and Tamil Nadu treat it).
2. **Reduce coconut-husk retting from Red to Green**, with mandatory Zero-Liquid-Discharge / common effluent safeguards, in line with the CPCB PI methodology and Tamil Nadu's White

treatment. Bleaching / dyeing / stencilling may remain regulated (Orange), as they alone involve chemicals.

3. **Sanction a coir Common Facility Centre and cluster status for Chittur** (mechanised de-fibring, pith washing / block-making with ZLD and salinity management), so that environmental safeguards are met collectively and cheaply.
4. **Ensure a level playing field with Pollachi** — including power-tariff parity and MSME incentives — so that the value of Kerala's own coconut husk is retained in Kerala.

6. Annexures

- **Annexure A** — KSPCB current classification of coir processes (December 2025).
- **Annexure B** — TNPCB: coir retained in the White category — the 10-11-2021 Orange reclassification and its withdrawal on 12-10-2023.
- **Annexure C** — Model draft Government Order for the Government's consideration.

Respectfully submitted,

For and on behalf of the coconut farmers of the Chittur Assembly Constituency,

Arun (authorised representative of the petitioner farmers)
[Phone / Email]

ANNEXURE A**KSPCB classification of coir processes — current list (December 2025)**

Transcribed from the Kerala State Pollution Control Board's current classification of industrial sectors. The source list is to be annexed to this petition in original.

Category	Coir activity	Consent regime
RED	Coconut-husk retting	CTE + CTO; public-hearing-tier possible
ORANGE	Coir de-fibring / ginning; coir stencilling; coir bleaching / dyeing	CTE + CTO; periodic monitoring
GREEN	Coir fibre / pith processing generating effluent	Simplified consent
WHITE	Dry coir processing / coir products without effluent; coir yarn without dyeing; coir-pith final product; coir rope; curled coir	Intimation only (no CTO)

ANNEXURE B

TNPCB — coir industry retained in the White category

Summary of the Tamil Nadu Pollution Control Board's position, with the operative dates and the text of its withdrawal order. Copies of the TNPCB proceedings / press release are to be annexed in original.

- **Baseline position:** Under the CPCB Pollution-Index norm (Red high, Orange / Green moderate, White non-polluting), the coconut-husk retting / de-fibering / pith-processing industry stands in the **White** category in Tamil Nadu.
- **Proceedings dated 10-11-2021:** TNPCB reclassified the coir industry from White to Orange — moving it into the polluting category, requiring TNPCB approval to set up units and subjecting them to periodic monitoring — stated to be pursuant to directions of the environmental tribunal / courts.
- **Withdrawal dated 12-10-2023:** Following an enormous number of representations from various associations of coir exporters and manufacturers seeking protection of the coir sector and their livelihood, TNPCB withdrew the Orange reclassification. The operative reasoning recorded was:

“Considering the coir industry is one of the vital agro-based cottage-type industries in the State contributing significantly to the creation of livelihood in major coconut-growing districts and to encourage the cottage-type MSME sector for the production of eco-friendly products, TNPCB withdraws the proceeding regarding the categorisation of coconut husk retting / de-fibres / pith processing under the Orange category.”

- **Effect:** The coconut-husk retting / de-fibering / pith-processing industry **remains in the White category in Tamil Nadu**, relieving these cottage / MSME units of Consent-to-Operate and monitoring burdens.

Relevance to this petition: Kerala keeps husk retting in Red and de-fibering / ginning in Orange for the **same raw material and the same process chain** that both Tamil Nadu and the Central norm treat as White, on the other side of the same district border. That contrast is the core justification for the re-alignment prayed for in paragraph 5.

ANNEXURE C

Model draft Government Order (for the Government's consideration)

The following is a model draft placed for the Government's consideration. The actual G.O. number, date and file references are to be assigned by the Department.

GOVERNMENT OF KERALA

Abstract

Environment Department – Coir sector in Chittur (Palakkad) – Re-alignment of the pollution-category of coconut-husk retting (Red → Green with ZLD) and coir de-fibring / ginning (Orange → White) with the CPCB Pollution-Index Directions and with the Tamil Nadu White-category treatment, and grant of a coir Common Facility Centre with cluster status – Orders issued.

ENVIRONMENT (POLLUTION CONTROL) DEPARTMENT

G.O.(Ms) No. ____/2026/Envvt. Thiruvananthapuram, dated __-__-2026

Read: 1. CPCB Directions dated 07-03-2016 (No. B-29012/ESS(CPA)/2015-16) u/s 18(1)(b) of the Water (Prevention and Control of Pollution) Act, 1974, and the subsequent CPCB Directions of 2025.
2. TNPCB proceedings dated 10-11-2021 and their withdrawal dated 12-10-2023.
3. Representation dated __-07-2026 of the coconut farmers of the Chittur Assembly Constituency, represented by Arun.

ORDER

Whereas coconut-husk retting and coir de-fibring / ginning are treated more stringently in Kerala (Red and Orange respectively) than the CPCB Pollution-Index norm requires, and than Tamil Nadu treats the identical process chain (White), causing these units and their employment to migrate to Pollachi (Tamil Nadu);

Government, having considered the matter, hereby order that –

- (1) the Kerala State Pollution Control Board shall re-align coir de-fibring / ginning to the White category and coconut-husk retting to the Green category with mandatory Zero-Liquid-Discharge safeguards, consistent with the CPCB Directions read above, retaining Orange regulation only for bleaching / dyeing / stencilling;
- (2) a coir Common Facility Centre with cluster status is sanctioned for Chittur (mechanised de-fibring, pith washing / block-making with ZLD and salinity management);
- (3) power-tariff parity with Tamil Nadu and MSME incentives shall be extended to coir units in Chittur; and
- (4) the Environment, Industries and Coir Directorates shall ensure a level playing field so that value addition to Kerala's coconut husk is retained within the State.

By order of the Governor,

Secretary to Government

To The Chairman, Kerala State Pollution Control Board; the Director of Industries & Commerce; the Director of Coir Development.

Copy to: the Chief Minister's Office; the Minister for Industries; the MLA, Chittur.